

Define the problem

CASE

NAME OR GROUP

DATE

1

The situation

In your own words, what is going on?

A warm-up, not the statement. Zone 2 is the statement.

2

The problem

What is there too much of, or too little of? For whom? Since when? Why does that matter?

There is [] too much [] too little

THE THING THERE IS TOO MUCH OR TOO LITTLE OF

for

WHO IT AFFECTS

since

WHEN

which matters because

THE CONSEQUENCE

Rationale: how and why people are affected. If the reason it matters is that something is unfair, say who bears what, compared with whom, and against which standard.

If excess and deficit does not fit, use the back of this sheet and say why the default form did not fit.

3

Is this the kind of problem the process is for?

Yes or no to each, with one line saying how you know.

Y	N		HOW YOU KNOW
☐	☐	Has this been going on, rather than happening once?	
☐	☐	Does it have a history you can describe?	
☐	☐	Have attempts to deal with it failed?	
☐	☐	Could a known procedure solve it, if someone chose to?	
☐	☐	Is it small enough to work on: can you say where it starts and stops, and could you describe what drives it in about a dozen variables?	

Left box yes, right box no. A yes to the fourth question is the one that disqualifies a topic: if a known procedure would solve it, the problem is a decision, not a system.

4

The desired change

If this changed for the better, what would be different? Say it in the same terms as the problem, and do not say how.

IN FIVE YEARS OR MORE

A NEARER POINT, ONE TO FIVE YEARS OUT

5

How others describe it

How is this problem currently described by those with power over it, and what does that description take for granted?

WHERE YOU READ IT

6

Your position

What is your position in relation to this system? Tick one.

☐ I am analysing from outside

☐ I act for an organisation or a cause

☐ I advise someone who decides

☐ I decide, or my organisation does

☐ I am affected by this

Read this against what you wrote

Nothing on this side needs writing space, except the one line in the first box.

When excess and deficit does not fit

It is the default form, not the only one. Take these in order, and choose one only with a line saying why the default did not fit. All of them carry the same five parts: the thing, the direction or the gap, who it affects, since when, and why it matters.

FORM	USE IT WHEN	WRITE IT LIKE THIS
Mismatch	The quantity is right, but it is in the wrong place, at the wrong time, or with the wrong people. "Too little housing" is false nationally and true in one city.	X exists, but not where (or when, or for whom) it is needed: it is at A while the need is at B.
Falling short of a standard	The thing exists and is counted, but fails a rule, a promise, or a quality that was set. Decisions are made, but late; care is delivered, but unevenly.	X falls short of Y: the standard says A, the practice is B.
Something that has not happened yet	A risk, or a capacity that does not exist at all. There is no series to be too high or too low.	If A continues, B becomes likely, and nothing currently prevents it.

☐ Default (too much or too little) ☐ Mismatch ☐ Falling short of a standard ☐ Not happened yet

WHY THE DEFAULT DID NOT FIT

Eight rules, read against the finished sentence

- One problem per statement.** If the sentence needs "and" to hold two things, you have two problems. Choose the one you can work on and park the other.
- Name a thing that can rise or fall.** Not "the system is failing" but "the share of applications decided within the legal term".
- No solution in the statement.** If the words name an action, an instrument, or an organisation that should act, they belong on the parked strip.
- No cause in the statement.** "Because the ministry underfunds it" is an answer the mapping has to earn, not a premise to start from.
- No blame in the statement.** If it says who is at fault, rewrite it so that someone who disagrees about the cause could still accept it as a description.
- Bound it.** Place, population, and period, so that the size test can be answered.
- A value can be the reason, not the fact.** "This is unfair" is why it matters, and the rationale has to say why it is unfair: who bears what, compared with whom, and against which standard.
- Plain words.** If a term would need explaining to someone outside the field, define it in the rationale or drop it.

Two examples, weak and rewritten

WEAK	WHY	REWRITTEN
"Air pollution in Europe is a serious problem and the EU should act."	Unbounded, names a solution, no measurable thing	There are too many days above the WHO particulate limit in Kraków, since the city's last clean air plan, which matters because it shortens healthy life expectancy for people living on the main roads.
"Housing is broken."	No thing, no direction, no bounds	There are too few social rental homes for registered applicants in Dublin, which matters because households on the list wait years for an offer.

The check before moving on. Read the finished sentence against two questions. Could someone who disagrees about the cause still accept it as a description? Could they say what would have to change for it to stop being true? If either answer is no, the sentence is carrying a cause, a blame, or a solution, and it is rewritten.